



Mental conditioning: Head coach Harendra Singh revealed that Hockey India has partnered with Bengaluru-based Behavioural Foresight, a performance science firm that helps athletes handle pressure: **Below:** Skipper Salima insists the leadership load is shared. PICS: HOCKEY INDIA

steadier defence and, with it, calmer teammates.

Hitting the mark

If defence is a concern, attack is equally so. Drag-flicker Deepika finished as India's top scorer with seven goals, six from penalty corners. That reliance could place unnecessary pressure on the forward.

"When we go to take a PC, of course, there'll be pressure. But inside that circle, if my teammates tell me, 'Do whatever you can, we are here to back you,' then I only need to focus on the goal," she smiled.

Before the European leg of the League, Deepika and Manisha Chauhan trained under drag-flick coach Toon Siepman. "Changing my body position during pick-up, correcting my footing, and tweaking the follow-through to increase the speed of the ball – these were the areas of focus," Deepika recalled.

India, however, struggled in front of goal: 22 strikes all season, the second-lowest tally (ahead of England's 20). Ten were field goals, 11 from penalty corners, and just one from penalty stroke. It also ranked last in circle penetrations (210).

"Where we fail is in the number of shots on goal. Look at penalty corners, we won them as many as the Netherlands and Belgium, but our conversion rate was low (13.75). In modern hockey, you try to hit that sweet spot of 24-28 per cent in a match," Harendra observed.

Back where it began

For Harendra, the Asia Cup is personal. It was his first assignment when he took over the women's team in 2017 — and he won the title.



India's squad for women's Asia Cup 2025

GOALKEEPERS: Bansari Solanki, Bichu Devi Kharibam

DEFENDERS: Manisha Chauhan, Udit, Jyoti, Suman Devi Thoudam, Nikki Pradhan, Ishika Chaudhary

MIDFIELDERS: Neha, Vaishnavi Vitthal Phalke, Salima Tete, Sharmila Devi, Lalremsiami, Sunelita Toppo

FORWARDS: Navneet Kaur, Rutaja Dadaso Pisal, Beauty Dungdung, Mumtaz Khan, Deepika, Sangita Kumari

"When I took charge of India on October 8, 2017, that was the first time that I took the job of a women's team. I had to fly to Japan on the 24th, so the preparation time was less, but many of the players were mature in that group," he remembered.

Between stints with India, Harendra led the U.S. men's team in 2021. "There, I got to learn a lot about the other aspects of hockey, the ones not related to the game on the turf. Mental toughness, decision-making, psychology, and well-being – they emphasise a lot on these things. Now that I'm back here, I try to do the same."

The 2017 team had established stars like Rani Rampal and Vandana Katariya. The current side is younger, but Harendra believes in its long-term trajectory. It is, in his words, "Mission 2028" — with the World Cup and Asian Games as stepping stones towards a Los Angeles Olympic medal.

"We know that if we win the Asia Cup, we will go to the World Cup. So there's no compromise on that. There's no ifs and buts. We have to win. Of course, there's another chance to qualify after this, but why wait?" Harendra, who still swears by his philosophy of "Indian masala hockey," concluded.



India women's schedule

India vs Thailand (September 5)

Japan vs India (September 6)

India vs Singapore (September 8)

